

A-level

ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENCE

Paper 1 - Generated practice paper Set 01

Mark scheme

120 marks: Questions 1-10 (95 marks) plus one essay from Question 11 (25 marks).

Marking guidance

- The number in brackets after each marking point is the mark it earns; the note above the points says how many are needed.
- Where a question asks for a fixed number of points (eg *two reasons*), credit only the first points given.
- Alternative correct wording and other relevant, accurate points are credited.
- For levels-of-response questions, first determine the level using the descriptors, then position the mark within the level using the indicative content.
- Calculations: credit correct working (method marks) even if the final answer is wrong; incorrect answers with no working score 0.

Textbook references: every question below cites the printed page numbers in R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018) from which the content is drawn, together with the AQA 7447 specification reference.

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
01.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • UV light splits diatomic oxygen (O₂) into two monatomic oxygen atoms (O) (1) • Monatomic oxygen reacts with diatomic oxygen to form ozone (O₃) (1) • UV light also splits ozone into O₂ and O; the reactions form a dynamic equilibrium which absorbs UV (converting it to chemical energy / heat) (1)	3
01.2	<i>Up to 6 marks in total; award marks in proportion to the completeness of each point.</i> • Useful: boiling points near ambient temperature so easily liquefied under low pressure (aerosol propellants, fridge / air-conditioning coolants); dissolve grease but do not damage electrical components (solvents); non-flammable; non-toxic (up to 2) • Persistence: chemically stable / unreactive in the troposphere so they remain long enough to be carried up to the stratosphere (up to 2) • Dissociation by UV: in the stratosphere higher UV levels break the carbon-chlorine bonds releasing chlorine free radicals (up to 2) • Chlorine reacts with monatomic oxygen (and ozone), preventing ozone formation; chlorine is regenerated so one atom destroys many ozone molecules; bromine / iodine act similarly (up to 2)	6
01.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • UVB energy is absorbed by cells and breaks up biological molecules / DNA causing mutations, skin cancer, cataracts, sunburn (human health) (1) • Damage to leaf tissue and reduced photosynthesis / crop yields (plants) (1) • Damage to marine algae, phytoplankton, corals and planktonic larvae (marine organisms), reducing productivity and food webs (1)	3

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
01.4	1 mark. • An area where the total ozone column falls below 220 Dobson Units (normal is about 300 DU) - a level never recorded before CFC pollution (1)	1
01.5	1 mark. • Concentration varies with altitude and the stratosphere is not normally sampled; Dobson Units measure the total column thickness instead (1)	1
01.6	1 mark. • The British Antarctic Survey at Halley detected higher UV at ground level, showing ozone above had decreased (satellites above the stratosphere cannot measure downward UV directly) (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 108-109; AQA spec 3.2.1.3.	
02.1	1 mark for each point. • Negative feedback: a change causes other changes that reduce the rate or size of the original change, re-establishing equilibrium (1) • Positive feedback: a change causes other changes that increase the original change (1)	2
02.2	2 marks for each point (partial credit for a partly correct point). • Increased low-level cloud: higher temperatures increase evaporation and condensation, producing more cloud; clouds have a high albedo so more sunlight is reflected and warming is reduced (2) • Increased photosynthesis: higher temperatures and CO ₂ increase photosynthesis, removing CO ₂ ; if stored in woody tissue atmospheric CO ₂ rises less (2)	4
02.3	1 mark for each point. • Permafrost: frozen waterlogged Arctic soils contain dead organic matter that decomposed anaerobically producing methane trapped in the frozen ground (1) • Warming thaws the permafrost, releasing methane (a powerful greenhouse gas) and allowing further decomposition, causing more warming (1) • Methane hydrate: methane from decomposed organic matter in deep sea sediments is held as a solid under high pressure and low temperature (1) • If deep water warms the hydrate melts, releasing methane into the atmosphere and causing further warming (1)	4
02.4	Any 3 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 3. • Reduced albedo as snow / ice melts (1) • Ocean acidification reducing coral survival and carbon sequestration (1) • Increased forest and peat fires releasing CO ₂ (1) • Faster decomposition of soil organic matter releasing CO ₂ (1) • Increased water vapour (a greenhouse gas) in warmer air (1) • Increased cirrus (high) cloud which traps infrared (1)	3
02.5	1 mark for each point. • A point at which natural processes triggered by human-caused warming become self-sustaining / unstoppable (1) • So that stopping the original human activity would no longer stop climate change (eg runaway permafrost melt, methane hydrate release, forest fires) (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 103-104, 371-372; AQA spec 3.2.1.2, 3.6.1.	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
03.1	<i>Correct answer only.</i> • C (1)	1
03.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Monitoring can be focused on the sites predicted to be most at risk / where the pollutant will concentrate (1) • No need to sample sites that were never likely to be polluted; sampling also checks the accuracy of the predictions (1)	2
03.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Behaviour of new chemicals can be predicted from similar existing chemicals: it is likely to persist, bioaccumulate and biomagnify (1) • So acceptable emission limits, control methods and monitoring programmes can be set before release (precautionary principle) (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 243-245; AQA spec 3.4.3.1.	
04.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Occupancy sensors detect infrared / movement and switch lights or appliances off when no one is in the room (1) • Programmable thermostats set different temperatures for different rooms and times so unused rooms / periods are not heated (1)	2
04.2	<i>Up to 3 marks in total; award marks in proportion to the completeness of each point.</i> • LEDs convert a much larger proportion of electricity to light rather than heat (up to 2) • Washing machines with cold / low-temperature cycles and fast spins (less drying); dishwashers using less water so less heating; cookers with double / triple glazed doors; fridges with linear compressors; LED screens using half the power of plasma; germanium transistors (up to 2)	3
04.3	<i>Any 3 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 3.</i> • Turning off lights / appliances rather than standby (1) • Turning thermostats and radiator valves down / off in unused rooms (1) • Only heating the water needed (kettle) (1) • Showering instead of bathing; eco-cycles (1) • Choosing smaller vehicles / less travel (1)	3
04.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Stored hot water loses heat continuously through the tank walls and pipes (1) • Heating as needed (or just before) avoids these standing losses; if storage is needed the tank should be well insulated (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 232-233; AQA spec 3.3.4.2.2.	
05.1	<i>Correct answer only.</i> • B - Low liposolubility and low persistence (1)	1
05.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Bioaccumulation: build-up of a pollutant in the tissues of an individual organism over time because uptake is faster than excretion / breakdown (1) • Biomagnification: increase in concentration of the pollutant at successive trophic levels of a food chain (1)	2

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
05.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • They are intended to be toxic (to the target species) (1) • They are deliberately released / spread into the environment (rather than being an accidental or waste release) (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 262-266; AQA spec 3.4.3.2.8.	
06.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Each regional population has its own unique gene pool / DNA profile (1) • DNA from seized timber or ivory is compared with the database of regional populations (1) • This identifies where the material came from, showing whether it was legally harvested and where poaching occurs (1)	3
06.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Radio / GPS transmitters use radio waves - work in air and fresh water, giving positions (GPS stores or transmits location) (1) • Radio waves do not travel through seawater so acoustic transmitters (sound) are used for marine animals, giving real-time positions (1)	2
06.3	<i>Up to 3 marks in total; award marks in proportion to the completeness of each point.</i> • Drones / ROVs, AUVs (eg Autosub), balloons, aircraft, satellites, animals (tags) (up to 2) • Drones: cheap, low disturbance, high-resolution images of areas hard to reach (cliffs, canopy, ice), repeated surveys; infrared cameras detect animals at night (up to 2)	3
06.4	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Cameras record automatically (visible light by day, infrared at night) without researchers being present (1) • So animals behave naturally and nests are not deserted; monitoring continues 24 hours (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 404-406; AQA spec 3.7.2.3.	
07.1	<i>Correct answer only.</i> • Organic (methyl) mercury (1)	1
07.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Anaerobic microbes converted the inorganic mercury into organic methyl mercury (1) • Methyl mercury is liposoluble so it is absorbed, crosses into the brain and biomagnifies along the food chain to fish eaten by people (1)	2
07.3	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Most heavy metals are less soluble at high pH (1) • So they remain immobile and are not leached into water or absorbed by organisms (1)	2
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 275-279; AQA spec 3.4.3.2.11.	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
08.1	Levels of response Level 3 (7-9 marks): Answer is comprehensive, relevant and logically structured. Shows detailed knowledge and understanding of the relevant scientific ideas and applies them accurately to the context. Evaluation/analysis is well supported by evidence and a clear judgement or conclusion is reached. Level 2 (4-6 marks): Answer is mostly relevant and shows some structure. Knowledge and understanding of relevant ideas is sound but application to the context or evaluation may be incomplete or lack detail. A judgement may be made but is not fully supported. Level 1 (1-3 marks): Answer is basic, with limited structure. Some relevant knowledge is shown but there are omissions or errors. Little application to the context and little or no evaluation. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (credit other relevant, accurate points) • Carbon: combustion of fossil fuels and biomass moving carbon from long-term stores to the atmosphere; deforestation reducing photosynthesis; ploughing / drainage increasing aerobic decomposition; new anaerobic environments (paddies, landfill, reservoirs, livestock) releasing methane; marine pollution reducing phytoplankton; consequences: rising CO₂ and CH₄, climate change, ocean acidification, reduced soil organic matter • Nitrogen: Haber process doubling fixation; legume cultivation; drainage increasing nitrification and reducing denitrification; combustion NO_x; sewage and fertiliser leaching; consequences: eutrophication, smogs, acid rain, N₂O warming, NO_x toxicity • Counter-strategies carbon: renewables / nuclear replacing fossil fuels, energy conservation, afforestation matched to deforestation and timber use, conserving peat bogs and forests, increasing soil organic matter (low tillage, mulching), CCS (pre / post combustion, storage) • Counter-strategies nitrogen: reduced combustion, catalytic converters / urea sprays, biological fixation instead of Haber, legumes and crop rotation, management of biological wastes as fertiliser, low-solubility fertilisers, timing, buffer strips, low tillage, nitrate vulnerable zones • Evaluation: some strategies well established and cheap (rotation, buffer strips), others expensive or unproven (CCS); scale of fossil fuel dependence; feedback and time lags; link to circular economy and low-temperature natural processes; judgement	9
08.2	<i>1 mark.</i> • The average time an atom / molecule remains in the reservoir before being transferred out (volume / transfer rate) (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 148-157; AQA spec 3.2.4.	
09.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • The void fills with water naturally; wetlands are uncommon / valuable habitats in most regions (1) • The new habitat may have greater wildlife value than the farmland lost; low cost compared with filling and levelling (1)	2

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
09.2	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Housing: ground must be stable (no subsidence), no toxic metal wastes (otherwise industrial use is safer) (1) • Farmland: landscape not too steep or uneven, no toxic materials, sufficiently fertile soil (topsoil replaced) (1)	2
09.3	<i>1 mark.</i> • Species that cannot be caught / found, or whose habitat requirements are unknown or hard to recreate, are lost; transplanted plants often fail (1)	1
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 140, 142; AQA spec 3.2.3.6.	
10.1	<i>1 mark for each point.</i> • Together they form a dispersed layer in the stratosphere (the ozone layer / ozonosphere) (1) • They absorb ultraviolet light, which drives a dynamic equilibrium of reactions that form and destroy ozone (1) • The UV energy is converted to chemical / heat energy so most UV that passed the upper atmosphere never reaches the surface (1)	3
10.2	<i>Any 2 from the points below - 1 mark each, maximum 2.</i> • Provides carbon, oxygen, hydrogen and nitrogen (as N₂, O₂, CO₂, H₂O) for biological molecules (1) • Delays the escape of infrared energy, keeping the surface warm (1) • Distributes heat and water vapour by winds / ocean currents (1) • Provides atmospheric pressure so liquid water can exist (1) • Deflects damaging radiation of the solar wind in the upper atmosphere (1)	2
10.3	<i>1 mark.</i> • Energy is absorbed at different altitudes (eg UV absorbed in the stratosphere, surface heating warms the troposphere) so temperature gradients change with altitude, producing layers (1)	1

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
10.4	Levels of response Level 3 (7-9 marks): Answer is comprehensive, relevant and logically structured. Shows detailed knowledge and understanding of the relevant scientific ideas and applies them accurately to the context. Evaluation/analysis is well supported by evidence and a clear judgement or conclusion is reached. Level 2 (4-6 marks): Answer is mostly relevant and shows some structure. Knowledge and understanding of relevant ideas is sound but application to the context or evaluation may be incomplete or lack detail. A judgement may be made but is not fully supported. Level 1 (1-3 marks): Answer is basic, with limited structure. Some relevant knowledge is shown but there are omissions or errors. Little application to the context and little or no evaluation. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (credit other relevant, accurate points) • Troposphere: enhanced greenhouse effect - anthropogenic CO₂ (fossil fuels, deforestation), methane (rice, livestock, landfill), N₂O, CFCs, tropospheric ozone; more infrared absorbed and re-emitted; aerosols and smoke increase albedo / scatter light; land-use change alters surface albedo and evapotranspiration • Stratosphere: CFCs / halons / HCFCs release chlorine and bromine which catalyse ozone destruction, shifting the O / O₂ / O₃ equilibrium; less UV absorbed in the stratosphere, more reaches the surface; stratospheric cooling • Consequences: changes to climate, ocean currents (thermohaline), hydrological cycle, sea level, species distributions; increased UV damage to organisms • Difficulties of prediction: linked processes where one change alters others; feedback (positive and negative) and tipping points; time lags (ocean heat capacity, long residence times of CFCs and CO₂); natural variability (solar output, volcanoes, Milankovitch cycles); incomplete understanding of atmospheric processes; limited historical data so proxies needed; models with different assumptions • Evaluation: some effects well understood (greenhouse physics, ozone chemistry proven, Montreal Protocol success) but scale and timing of regional impacts uncertain; precautionary principle • Justified conclusion	9
	Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 86-89, 108-113; AQA spec 3.2.1.1, 3.2.1.3.	

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
11.1	Discuss the extent to which the study of ozone depletion illustrates how scientific investigation can lead to the successful solution of an environmental problem. Levels of response Level 5 (21-25 marks): Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. Level 4 (16-20 marks): Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. Level 3 (11-15 marks): Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. Level 2 (6-10 marks): Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. Level 1 (1-5 marks): Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (students are not expected to cover all of these; credit other relevant material) • Stages of investigation: identifying the issue (Halley Station UV data, Dobson unit measurements), hypothesis formation (Rowland-Molina 1974: persistence, UV dissociation, chlorine reactions), data collection (ground, satellite, balloon and aircraft air sampling detecting ClO), analysis of spatial, temporal and altitude variability, proposal of solutions, enactment • Why Antarctica: low stratospheric temperatures, ice crystals, stratospheric clouds, polar vortex, spring sunlight • Effects of UVB: skin cancer, cataracts, DNA damage, plant and marine damage - motivating action • Solutions: Vienna Convention, Montreal Protocol - phase-out and bans, alternative processes (pump sprays), alternative materials (HCFCs, HFCs, hydrocarbons, HFAs), collection and incineration of CFCs, fund for developing countries • Evaluation of success: ozone hole area / depth stabilising, CFC levels falling; limitations - persistence, remaining ODSs, HFCs as greenhouse gases, decades to full recovery • Comparison with other atmospheric problems (climate change, acid rain) - why ozone was easier; role of peer review, international cooperation, availability of substitutes • Conclusion on the extent to which it is a model for other issues Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 108-113; AQA spec 3.2.1.3.	25

Question	Marking guidance	Marks
11.2	Discuss the difficulties in monitoring and predicting global climate change and evaluate the methods used to overcome them. Levels of response Level 5 (21-25 marks): Comprehensive and detailed knowledge and understanding drawn from across the specification, applied accurately to the question. Argument is coherent, well-structured and supported by a wide range of relevant, well-chosen examples and quantitative detail where appropriate. Interconnections between topics are made explicitly and a clear, justified conclusion is reached. Level 4 (16-20 marks): Detailed knowledge and understanding with good application to the question. Argument is logically organised with relevant examples; some links between different areas of the specification are made. Conclusions are drawn but may be less fully justified. Level 3 (11-15 marks): Sound knowledge and understanding, mostly applied to the question. Some structure and relevant examples, but coverage may be uneven or descriptive rather than analytical. Limited linking of topics. Level 2 (6-10 marks): Basic knowledge and understanding with partial relevance. Answer is largely descriptive with few examples and limited structure; some errors or omissions. Level 1 (1-5 marks): Limited, fragmented knowledge with little relevance to the question. Little structure; examples absent or inappropriate. 0 marks: No relevant content. Indicative content (students are not expected to cover all of these; credit other relevant material) • Nature of the problem: interconnected atmosphere-hydrosphere-biosphere systems; changes over different time and spatial scales; natural fluctuations (solar output, orbit) masking or exaggerating anthropogenic change; time delay between cause and effect (ocean heat capacity) • Limitations of historic data: sparse global coverage, unsophisticated equipment, heat island bias, no atmospheric composition records • Proxy data and their reliability: dendrochronology, coral growth rings, pollen in dated sediments, ice cores (gas bubbles, isotope ratios, volcanic ash layers, compaction problems) • Modern monitoring: long-term data sets (Mauna Loa), electronic equipment, satellites (LEO vs geostationary), Argo floats, remote sensing of ice thickness / area / sea level • Feedback mechanisms and tipping points adding uncertainty; ecological uncertainty (species survival, distribution, fragmentation) • Computer models: how they are tested and refined; importance of accurate representative data; scenario-based predictions and ranges • Uncertainty over ENSO / Conveyor / jet stream responses • Evaluation and conclusion: confidence in the overall trend and human cause despite detailed uncertainty; role of peer review and international bodies (IPCC) Source: R. Genn, Environmental Science A level AQA (Insight & Perspective, 2018), pp. 89-90, 100-104, 10; AQA spec 3.2.1.2, 3.1.1.3.	25